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War and Literature II

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From the Committee

War was the first subject of literature; at times, war has been its only subject. In this volume, the contributors reflect on the uneasy yet symbiotic relations of war and writing, from medieval to modern literature. War writing emerges in multiple forms, celebratory and critical, awed and disgusted; the rhetoric of inexpressibility fights its own battle with the urgent necessity of representation, record and recognition. This is shown to be true even to the present day: whether mimetic or metaphorical, literature that concerns itself overtly or covertly with the real pressures of war continues to speak to issues of pressing significance, and to provide some clues to the intricate entwinement of war with contemporary life. Particular topics addressed include writings of and about the crusades and battles during the hundred years war; Shakespeare's "casus belly"; Auden's "journal of an airman"; and war and peace.

The Trench Poets (The War Poets)

As the World War I breaks out, a great number of young people die in the trenches.

Most felt their duty to do so, they acted on an impulse, thinking it was an honourable thing to go and fight, even die for one's country. War was glorified as a noble thing; it was the question of honour.

That was the usual way in which poetry was written. In poetry, war was usually depicted as an honourable, glorious affair. Thousands of young men left their homes with this conviction. However, those very few who survived the war, returned changed, wiser, more cynical, they experienced the horrors of the war first hand

Many turned to writing, became artists, trying to escape from the trauma of war. The name war poetry might be misleading somewhat, because it is actually the anti-war poetry, the poetry presented attack against the whole ideology of nobleness of war.

They are not modernists, in terms of form or language they use. They are modern. It is a kind of modern poetry. Naturalistic and painfully realistic, with shocking images and language, intending to show what the war really like, the war poetry showed the mud, the trenches, death, and sometimes even compassion for soldiers.

The overall message through such poetry is that the war is brutal, vicious, meaningless, stupid and barbarous; there was nothing honourable, glorious, or decorous about the war. The daily experience of soldiers on the front was of mental disorders, nervous breakdown, caused by constant fear and pressure.

The Trench Poets question the very notion of war, heroism, patriotism, etc., they attacked the values of the pre war society in general.

The war poetry is a negation of Georgian poetry.Georgian poets were considered as modern as one can be. They were very patriotic; their poetry was very artificial, bombastic, their favourite themes were the beauty of the English countryside and their poetry lacked any poetic or philosophical depth. They regularly presented war as a noble affair, as an opportunity for the young Englishmen to ennoble their lives and turn from ordinary citizens to heroes. To them the war was seen as something giving a chance to young people to become ennobled by the experience of the war.

However, the war poets adopted quite opposite views of the war and of the Georgian society. Most prominent among them were Siegfried Sassoon, Wilfred Owen and Isaac Rosenberg.

Conclusion on War Poetry:

As a conclusion on war poetry, we have to say it differs from the poetry which preceded it, namely the Georgian poetry. So a clear break is made from the Georgian poetry. They communicate strong anti war messages. For war poets the war in unnatural, meaningless, foolish, brutal, enterprise in which there can be no winners, it is not a noble, heroic enterprise.

By,

S. Fathima Riswana

The literary effects of world war I

World War One was a cataclysmic event not only in terms of world history, but also for the literary world. The war's extreme brutality led to an outpouring of literature concerning its conduct and effects that began with the war poets themselves, extended through the interwar period, and reappeared periodically throughout the twentieth century. For this project, I have used traditional literary analysis to explore the war's effect on literature – specifically, I analyzed the work of five poets and six novelists. I chose these works based on personal preference, chronological range, and the recommendations of my advisor. In addition, I relied on secondary sources by Modris Eksteins and Paul Fussell for cultural contexts, biographical background, and specific details concerning trench warfare. Other works influenced the project, even if not extensively considered, and are noted in the Works Cited pages. In this project, I have sought to confirm and call attention to the literary effects of the Great War; its importance cannot be underestimated when we consider British literature of the twentieth century. In order to emphasize this point, I have considered not only "traditional" war literature – the poetry of Siegfried Sassoon, Wilfred Owen, Isaac Rosenberg, and Robert Graves – but also novels by Modernists D.H. Lawrence, Virginia Woolf, poetry by T.S. Eliot, and even later novels by Evelyn Waugh, W. Somerset Maugham, Pat Barker, and Robertson Davies. In evaluating these works, I found that the war remains a common theme in the lives of characters, whether real or fictional, but that the nature of the war experience changes over time. For instance, while World War One is a source of horror and suffering to the war poets, it becomes the harbinger of personal growth and change for characters in The Razor's Edge, by W. Somerset Maugham and Fifth Business, by Robertson Davies. I introduced Pat Barker's novel Regeneration out of chronological sequence (by date of publication) in order to accentuate the fact that the novel, published in the late twentieth century, engages with texts from the Modernist period without responding directly to World War Two-era (and later) works. I feel that Barker's work is a significant hinge in the research project, since it reflects one of my own purposes in pursuing this research: to explore and renew interest in World War One and in the experiences of men who lived, fought, and died in the trenches. My thesis is devoted to portraying the Great War and its consequences in a new shade of light by emphasizing the complexity, importance, and power of its literature. I hope that I have succeeded.

By,
M.Vinothraj

The effects of the hundred years war on English literature

The Hundred Years' War was an ongoing struggle between the English and the French during the 14th and 15th centuries over a number of issues, including legitimate claim to the French throne. Generations of English and French claimants to the crown were involved in the dispute, from approximately 1337 to 1453. At the Battle of Orleans in 1429, the French, led by Joan of Arc, defeated the English and drove them from most French territories. Following the Hundred Years' War, many English regarded French as the enemy's language. The status of the English language rose, and Oxford and Cambridge universities were founded. Although books were still hand-copied and expensive, literacy increased.

During the Hundred Years' War, the English seized on Arthur and adopted the Arthurian legends to define themselves, politically and in terms of religion. The late 14th century's "Sir Gawain and the Green Knight" offered a protagonist who, as a literary character, could be traced back to pre-conquest England. His name might be Welsh in origin. "Sir Gawain and the Green Knight" is constructed with an alliteration technique consisting of repeating sounds at word beginnings, a literary device that is uniquely English and not French in development. An example is the work's opening line, which reads "Sithen the sege and the assaut was sesed at Troye."

Piers Plowman

William Langland's allegorical poem "Piers Plowman" from this period features a prologue with a famous scene of a bell placed around a cat's neck. It's often considered symbolic of the fate of Richard II, 10 years old when he rose to the English throne. He was advised during his teen years by John of Gaunt, whose son Henry ultimately imprisoned Richard in the Tower of London. The image of John of Gaunt advising the young Richard pervades this era's literature. It also appears in politically themed poems including "Richard the Redeless" and "There Is a Busche That Is Forgrowe," as well as a short political allegory entitled "On the Times."

Chaucer

Geoffrey Chaucer began his landmark "The Canterbury Tales" in the early 1380s, a literary turning point in that he chose to write in English. "The Canterbury Tales" is typically considered the first great work of English literature. Chaucer's Middle English proved a viable language in which to write, alongside both French and Latin. Chaucer introduced approximately 2,000 new words into Middle English. Although it's likely they were everyday words in use in London in the 14th century, it is in Chaucer's works where they appear in written form for the first time.

An English Bible

In 1384, John Wycliffe published his Bible translation in English. At the time, this was regarded as an act of defiance or revolution, and the church banned the English translation. In spite of these difficulties, Wycliffe's Bible was a landmark English language work. By the late 14th and 15th century, the English language had evolved rapidly. It's not likely that even Chaucer would have understood the Old English that had evolved into his Middle English. In fact, Chaucer's Middle English is a rich English, and his work features the same themes

Imperious Army

Here
Rushed the Black Army,
Against hounding winds,
Roaring fiercely
Marched thunderously – soon
Trembled the native habitants –soldiers
Surrounded the city and hovered over there
Dead silence there ruled indicating the horror – far
heard a faded sound of temple bell.
The angry wind dashed against all it faced.
It scattered the imperious army
People in the city rushed inside
The Army felt proud of its coup.
The harsh wind unnerved and dispelled all.

Now prevailed there a cold breeze,
Along with thunder and lighting,
The dense black Army of clouds
Showered the water with its fullest might
After being genuine in its duty, it
Started to stroll away along with its
Mighteous and imperious army of "Black Rainy Clouds"

- *R. Mangalaeswari*

Facts to Know

Poets and poetry from Shakespeare to Marianne Moore

- E. E. Cummings dedicated his self-published volume of poetry, No Thanks, to the fourteen publishers who had turned it down.
- In the source poem for Romeo and Juliet, Juliet is 15. Nobody knows why Shakespeare chose to make her 13 in his play.
- The word ‘syphilis’ is derived from the name of an afflicted character in a 1530 poem by Italian physician Girolamo Fracastoro.
- An 1852 edition of John Milton’s Poetical Works was bound in the skin of a murderer, George Cudmore.
- John F. Kennedy’s favourite poem was ‘I Have a Rendezvous with Death’ by Alan Seeger.
- The word ‘unfriend’ as a noundates from around 1275, meaning ‘one who is not a friend’. It is found in Layamon’s medieval epic poem Brut.
- German poet Gottlob Burmann so despised the letter R that he avoided using it in his poetry – and in everyday conversation.
- Poet Marianne Moore was asked by the Ford Motor Company to come up with names for new cars. One of her suggestions was ‘Mongoose Civique’.
- The phrase ‘namby pamby’ originated as a nickname for Ambrose Philips, eighteenth-century poet lampooned for his babyish verses.
- The last line of the Robert Burns poem ‘Auld Lang Syne’ should strictly be ‘For auld lang syne’, not ‘For the sake of auld lang syne’. What’s more, Burns didn’t technically write the poem.
- Seventeenth-century poet Sir John Suckling invented the card game cribbage.
- Lizzie Doten’s 1863 book, Poems from the Inner Life, included poems which Doten claimed to have received from the ghost of Edgar Allan Poe.
- Poet Amy Lowell once bought a stash of 10,000 cigars, claiming she needed them to help her write.

- The word ‘pamphlet’ is derived from a fourteenth-century comic love poem ‘Pamphilius; or, Concerning Love’. Pamphilius means ‘lover of all’.

- According to legend, Chinese poet Li Po died when he drunkenly attempted to grasp the reflection of the moon in the still waters of a lake.

- ‘Flyting’ is the term for a poetic slanging-match, where two poets assail each other in turn with streams of abusive verse.
- Metrophobia’ is the name for a fear of poetry.

- ‘Metromania’ denotes the compulsion to write poetry.

- Sir Walter Scott composed much of his bestselling epic poem ‘Marmion’ while on horseback.

- The ancient epic Indian poem the Mahabharata runs to over 100,000 lines.

- Herman Melville’s 1876 work Clarel: A Poem and Pilgrimage in the Holy Land is the longest published poem in American literature.

- George MacDonald (1824-1905) wrote a two-word poem called ‘The Shortest and Sweetest of Songs’. It simply reads: ‘Come Home.’

- The epitaph on Emily Dickinson’s gravestone in Amherst, Massachusetts, composed by the poet herself, features just two words: ‘called back’.

- The rule prohibiting the ending of a sentence with a preposition was invented by 17th-century poet John Dryden. Most grammarians ignore him.

- ‘Rhapsodomancy’ is divining the future by picking a passage of poetry at random.

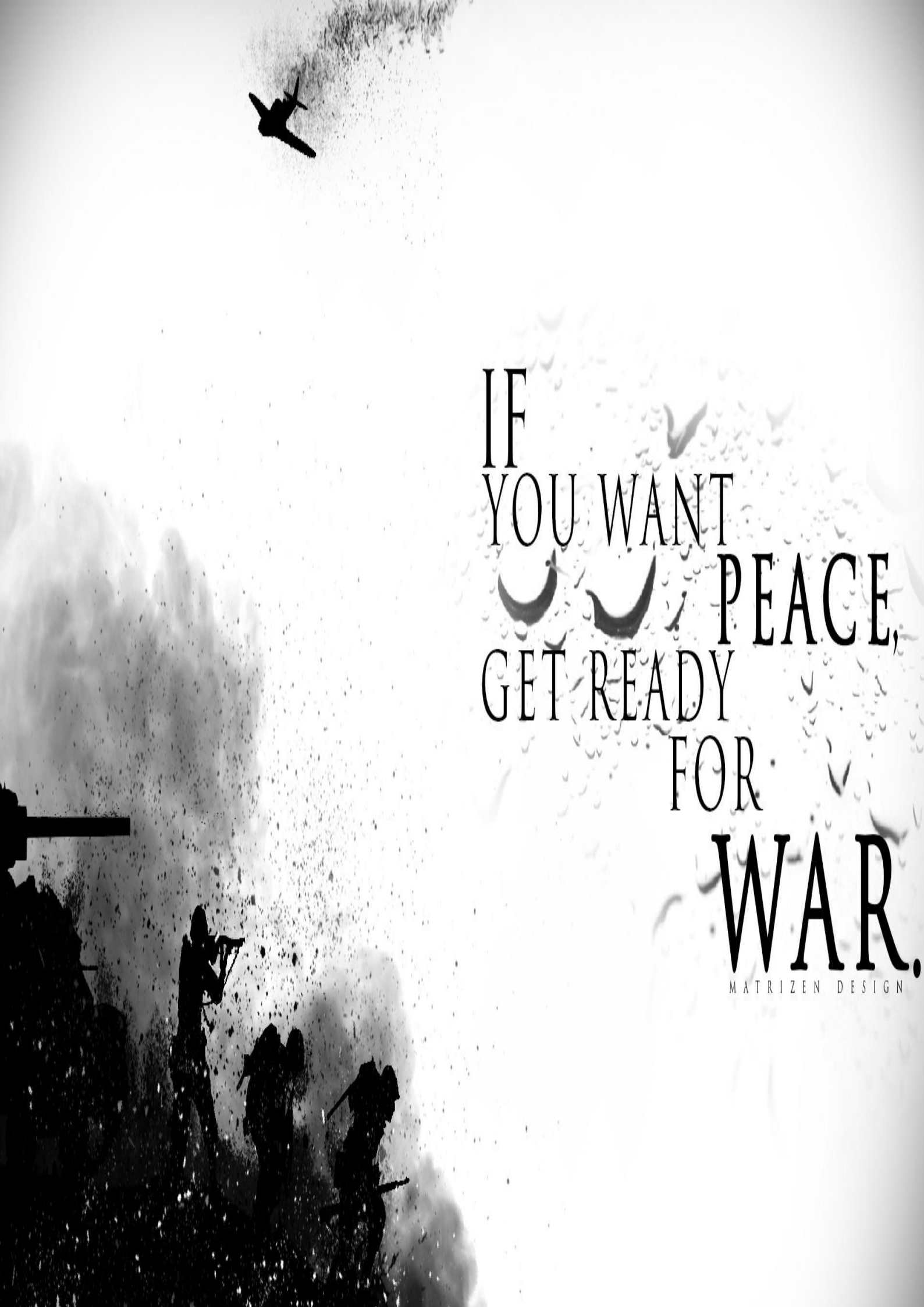
- The three biggest-selling poets in the world are Shakespeare, Lao-Tzu, and Khalil Gibran.

- G. K. Chesterton wrote a poem called ‘Plakkopytrixophylisperambulantiobatrix’.

- The word ‘bitch’ was first used in reference to a man in a poem from around 1500.

- The Greek epic poet Homer is thought to have written a (sadly all but lost) poem called Margites, about an exceedingly stupid man.

- The last words of poet Lady Mary Wortley Montagu were ‘It’s all been very interesting.’


IF
YOU WANT
PEACE,
GET READY
FOR
WAR.
MATRIZEN DESIGN